

Q I live in a city. Will the air pollution harm my baby?

If you minimize your outdoor activities during peak pollution times then you will also lower the chances of pollution affecting your baby. You would have to be exposed to excessive amounts to cause serious harm to you or your baby.

In 2014, a study at the University of Florida concluded that women living in heavily polluted urban areas were more likely to suffer high blood pressure and resulting preeclampsia during pregnancy. Another study in Poland, which followed children from birth until the age of five, concluded that high pollution levels during fetal development and in the first years of life led to a small drop in the child's IQ. The Harvard School of Public Health has also recorded links between fine particulate pollution (emitted by fires, vehicles, and industrial smokestacks) and autism during the third trimester.

Although these findings seem alarming, we already know that air pollution is bad for our health, so, while we need much more research to be certain of the effects on a pregnant woman and her unborn baby, it makes sense to exercise caution whenever you can. Walk down the street at times of

low traffic, avoiding rush hour, for example, and keep the windows at home closed at these times, too. If you can, invest in a home air purifier. Walk along quiet streets with traffic that keeps moving, or, ideally, through parks, rather than walking beside stationary traffic. And drink plenty of fluids to keep flushing out your system.

AIR QUALITY CHART

An air quality index is used by many government agencies around the world to notify the public of pollution forecasts on a daily basis. Although each one varies slightly, they usually cover measurements of ground-level ozone, particulate matter, carbon monoxide, sulfur dioxide, and nitrogen dioxide. Check local news media for air quality forecasts and plan outdoor activities for days when particle and ozone levels are low. Pregnant women should always follow the advice for at-risk individuals.

AIR POLLUTION BAND	HEALTH ADVICE FOR AT-RISK INDIVIDUALS
 Low	Enjoy your usual outdoor activities
 Moderate	Consider reducing prolonged or heavy outdoor activity
 High	Reduce or reschedule outdoor activities
 Very High	Avoid all outdoor exertion



Living in a polluted city Try to keep your windows closed during peak pollution times and follow any instructions from health officials for residents.

Q I've got cats. Is it safe for me to clean out their litter box?

Ideally not. Cat feces can carry the *toxoplasma gondii* parasite, which causes toxoplasmosis in humans. If you're pregnant and you become infected, it can cause miscarriage or stillbirth, brain damage, sight or hearing loss, or an enlarged spleen or liver in your baby. The earlier in your pregnancy you're infected, the less likely it is that you'll pass the parasite on to your baby, but if you do, the risks are greater. Later in your pregnancy you're more likely to pass on the infection, but the risks for complications are much lower.

Signs of toxoplasmosis infection in a baby only become clear over time, although babies may have a low birthweight, or show signs of jaundice or anemia. Most women who own cats have had the infection, and as long as they were infected more than three months before conception, there's no risk to the baby. It's best

to err on the side of caution, so ask someone else to clean the litter box. If that's not possible, wear rubber gloves and wash your hands immediately afterward. The parasite is also found in soil and raw meat so it is vital to wash your hands after gardening or handling raw meat and wash fruit and vegetables before you eat them. If you think you are at risk of toxoplasmosis, ask your doctor to test you.

Q I live in an old house that still has lead water pipes. Will drinking the tap water harm my baby?

For health reasons, even when you aren't pregnant, you should avoid contact with toxic "heavy" metals as much as possible. Lead in water can leach from your blood and bones and enter your unborn baby's system, and has been known to slow brain development in some children, both before and after birth. Some

countries have local government programs that subsidize (or even provide free) replacement of domestic lead water pipes. Talk to your local government about programs in your area and have the piping replaced if you can. Meanwhile, drink filtered water (a simple filter pitcher does a great job of removing impurities—including mercury and aluminum, as well as lead—from tap water) and use filtered water in cooking. If you prefer, use bottled mineral water, but make sure that it has the lowest available sodium levels.

Limit your exposure to toxic heavy metals by using glass, stainless steel, or ceramic cookware rather than pans and dishes made from aluminum or lead.